



Massimo Costantini back as TT coach



Italy's Massimo Costantini has been chosen as the foreign coach of the Indian table tennis team for a two-year term. He is expected to reach India soon. The 66-year-old was the Indian team's coach on two previous occasions, from 2009 to 2010 and from 2016 to 2018. During his period, India won a record eight medals at the 2018 Commonwealth Games and two bronze medals at the 2018 Asian Games.

Massimo, who competed in the 1988 Summer Olympics, has been admired by quite a few Indian players, including 10-time national champion Sharath Kamal.

Since Massimo left in 2018, the team hasn't had the services of a foreign coach. The Indian team can finally breathe easy with the arrival of its first foreign coach in six years.

In a message to *Sportstar*, India's paddler Harmeet Desai said, "It's great to have a national team coach after such a long time. We won't have much time to train under him before the Olympics, but we will all try our best to make the best use of what is left. We have had great results under Massimo, and I hope that we can do even better this time."

K. KEERTHIVASAN

» INDIAN PLAYGROUND

SPORTOON



1 Nitin Narang, the recently-elected president of AICF, has announced a budget of Rs. 65 crore to promote chess. During the AICF general body meeting, various important initiatives were discussed to strengthen the Indian chess ecosystem. These initiatives will provide financial and institutional support to both professional and grassroots-level players. There were talks around multiple proposals such as the introduction of a chess development fund, financial backing with player contracts, coaching at all levels, and financial support to district and state associations.

TEAM SPORTSTAR

2 Buoyed by the recent success of its young amateurs, the Indian Golf Union (IGU) has spread its activities to 'Training the Trainers' and 'Growing the Game' to grow the game in the country. The IGU has brought an international trainer to have special sessions with teaching professionals and coaches. "Time and again, we have been told at international meetings how the fraternity looks at India to grow the game in the region. We have the numbers, we have a coaches certification system and we are hopeful that in the next few years, India will be a golfing force," said IGU president Brijinder Singh.

TEAM SPORTSTAR